All I can picture is blood

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/85472806.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by Lisra

Summary

Catra and Adora deal with the aftermath of a bad episode.

Notes

CW: Discussion of self harm, not especially graphic but direct. Implied abuse and more self harm.

I was going to bed but instead I wrote this.

See the end of the work for more notes

“There you go,” Catra said as she put Adora’s arm back into the blonde’s lap. The lid of the first aid kit snapped shut and it was pushed back under the bed. Catra let herself fall back from where she had been kneeling in front of Adora. Her ears gently drooped and her tail swished.

“So, are you going to talk to me?” Catra challenged, not raising her voice. She hadn’t raised her voice at all, Adora realized. She had been quick, calm and efficient, but now whatever had propelled her forwards was clearly running out and the mask of worry that came over her face stabbed right into Adora’s heart.

“I…,” she began, but the words came out as if they had a mind of their own, “it’s not…”

“Don’t,” Catra whispered and her face changed. Adora saw worry, pain and anger in the face of the only person she loved. The person her entire world revolved around and who was the reason she was sitting here. Sitting here in this tiny room that was theirs and theirs alone, paid for and all, which had a lock and to which only they had the key in a building no one would look twice at far away from where they had run away from. The person she was inflicting grief upon by her inability to cope.

Adora shook her head and help up her undamaged hand as if to call for more time. Her gaze drifted towards the floor. The black had risen up inside her again. You are worthless, it said, you were supposed to be good but you are broken and you have caused harm like you always did and will again because even here, away from it all and with the one you claim to love, you can only cause pain.

“No,” Adora forced the word out, took a deep breath and repeated, “no.”

Catra hadn’t moved but was still looking at her, anger gone.

“No?” She asked.

“I’m not okay,” Adora admitted. Her thoughts laughed at her. As if that wasn’t obvious.

“Dor,” Catra ventured, her tail thumping once on the floor, “were you trying…”

Adora waved her hand.

“No, no, it wasn’t… that…” It hadn’t been. It had never been that. But it sure looked like it, she had to admit. There was a tiny change in the position of Catra’s ears.

They sat in silence, as Adora tried to figure out what else to say.

“I have always noticed,” Catra ventured after a while, “but I always… I always thought it came from somewhere else. Sport. Fighting. From her.”

“Some did,” Adora confirmed and she shivered at Catra’s low growl.

“But not all.”

Adora nodded.

“But not all.”

There was a tiny bit of liberation in admitting something. But it would mean nothing.

“Then why?”

The question made no sense. Adora’s eyes flickered directly to Catra’s own arms. She was lucky, many of her scars where partially masked by her fur.

“Don’t you know?” she asked back, and then added, “I’m not deflecting.”

Catra’s stare was unbroken.

“I know why I did it, but I can’t read your thoughts, love. And I want to know them, because I just had the biggest fright since the night we ran away.”

She scooted closer, almost touching Adora’s knees.

The weight that pressed down on Adora was enormous. Water rushed in her ears and her next breath stuttered.

She opened her unhurt hand and sought Catra’s eyes.

Catra understood, because she always did. She gently took Adora’s hand and squeezed it.

“Breaths, Adora, take breaths. Count and breathe. Count and breathe.”

The counted and they breathed. When the pressure had gone, Adora didn’t let go.

“You know how when it all becomes too much your mind starts to wander? You feel this heaviness and the pain and the need to move, but you can’t and your mind starts going in circles about this and that and the pain you are feeling and then it circles and circles like a fucking spiral and I see things in my head, like I can’t stop thinking about them and eventually all I see is… this,” she nodded at her bandaged arm, “all I see in front of my eyes is my doing that. Hurting myself, over and over again. And when I do it it just stops. It’s quiet. And I go and then it’s okay. For a while. And then the thoughts return, not those, but all the others. You know them. Feeling worthless. A disappointment and a danger who will never achieve anything because she’s… because she is broken. And eventually I see it again. Me, doing it and then…”

She stopped, because talking was no longer possible, with tears running down her face and her hands shaking. The wound on her arm send little burning sensations down into her wrist and up into her shoulder.

Catra was suddenly behind her and then her arms wrapped around Adora and she leaned back into the warm embrace, crying until her body was heavy from exhaustion. It had felt like an avalanche inside her, everything just tumbling down, smashing away whatever lay in its path until it all came to rest at the bottom.

"I will kill her," Catra whispered, "One day I will kill her for what she did to us and all the others. But Adora…," she nuzzled and kissed the messy blonde head, "Dor', I love you. I love you so much I can't put it into words. Never doubt or forget that. And it's…," she too struggled with finding words, "it's not exactly how it was for me, but I get you. But this… Dor', this can't go on. It can't."

Adora knew what she meant. She knew what her thoughts wanted her to believe what it meant. They would make her believe that Catra would go now, leave her for the broken mess she was and save herself.

She knew her thoughts lied. They lied all the time. But they were such good liars.

"Dor', I love you. I love you so much. But I can't do this by myself. We can't do this alone."

Adora was scared. She knew that. Scared of the search, scared of going to some stranger, scared of telling them too much, too little or the wrong things. But she was more scared of losing Catra. And of losing herself with it, of listening one too many times and becoming what the lying thoughts told her about herself. She was scared of dying. Once, she hadn't been. But things had changed. She had a side of the bed, her own clothes and a favorite place to go for coffee and cake. She had work where she learned to be helpful in ways that had nothing to do with the future the shadow of her childhood had planned for her. She had a favorite poster on their wall.

Catra was right. One day harming herself would stop giving relief and start to take.

She nodded and turned and twisted until she was buried in Catra's shirt.

"We have friends now," she whispered as she listened to Catra's heartbeat, "maybe they can help."

They did have friends now, people who had only heard about the vicious system that had clutched them until they had run away. But they were kind and perhaps they knew people. Knowing people was important in the real world.

They could not do it alone. And they would not.

Catra pressed another kiss on Adora's head.

"That's my idiot, already thinking about a way."

Adora pressed herself against the smaller girl as if she could crawl inside her. She could feel Catra's tail curling around her. Catra was trying to hold all of her with her entire self.

With effort, Adora pulled back a little and forced herself to look at Catra, through eyes that were burning and with a face that felt bruised and puffy.

"I love you too, Catra, and I'm…"

Catra cut her off, "don't say it, I know you are. Don't apologize. You're not broken. We're not broken."

Adora felt a rush to argue, but she did not. She was tired. All that mattered was that Catra knew.

She leaned back into Catra.

"I need water," she mumbled.

Catra sighed. I can get us both some if you let for a moment and then we can lie down, how does that sound?”

Adora watched her at the little fridge. An overwhelming sense of gratitude came over her. But she did not let her thoughts win this one. She knew why Catra was here with her. She just hoped she would never forget.

“Thank you,” Adora said and even managed something approaching a smile as Catra came back to the bed.

The look Catra gave her was one only Adora got to see and only Adora knew what it meant.

“I don’t do this because I like you,” Catra said, because it was true and they both knew what she meant.

“Nap now. And then I will make a call.”

“Nap first,” Adora agreed.

She felt at peace now, snuggled against Catra. But the thoughts would return, they always did. She would see images of herself again, as if drawing blood could wash everything away. They always came back. But perhaps she could be ready for them. Or at least not face them alone again.

End Notes

I have been in something of a writer's block and I felt this was a good moment to get some of my thoughts about this subject down through both our lovelies. The background of this AU is just a sketch but fwiw I picture them as running away from an orphanage and they are now living on their own in a boarding house. They met Bow through a social program.

Whoever needs to hear this, you are not alone and a better day will come.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!